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MSI 865PE Neo2

Turbo-charged mobo

The 865PE Neo2 motherboard supports hyper-threading and 800 MHz FSB.

The 865PE Neo2 sports the usual clean layout, with no capacitors cramped around the CPU area, making the installation of the HSF fuss-free. The most attractive feature of this board is the North-bridge fan with neon lights, which keep blinking once the system is switched on. The board comes

with a dynamic overclocking feature, which, when enabled, dynamically over-

clocks the system for getting the maximum out of it when running system-intensive applications. The Core cell chip is a controller on the motherboard that controls the dynamic OC, the fan speeds of the processor and North-bridge, etc.

The 865Neo2 boasts of support for dual-channel DDR 400 MHz memory and Gigabit LAN. The board has a Promise SATA RAID controller supporting 2 SATA and 1 IDE with RAID 0, 1 and 0+1 functions. The board has six onboard USB ports on the back panel and two in the front.

We tested the board with a 3.2 GHz Pentium 4 processor running Windows XP, an ATi 9800 128 MB graphics card and Corsair 400 MHz memory. The 865PE Neo2 gave some stunning results. In the CPU tests, it crossed the 10,000 mark on the Dhrystone value. Similarly, the multimedia FPU

was recorded as high as 23,583 in the SiSoft Sandra benchmark, indicating the superb and seamless CPU sub-system on the board. In Quake 3 Arena, the fps never dropped below 450, and recorded a maximum of 556 fps in the fastest mode. This can be attributed to the 800 MHz FSB and the DDR 400 MHz in operation. The video encoding was completed in just 71



seconds—one second ahead of the Gigabyte GA-7NNXP. The board returned 42.9 and 33.3 units in the content creation and Business Winstone benchmark, posting the best scores till date. When dynamic overclocking was enabled in the BIOS, the scores took a jump, with the fps in Quake 3, getting a boost of around 15 frames; similarly in 3D Mark 2003, the score again showed a boost of around 17 units.

The MSI 865PE Neo2 is definitely expensive, but makes up on features and performance. If you want a full featured motherboard for a Pentium 4 platform, this has to be it.

SPECIFICATIONS

Supports Intel Pentium 3.2C GHz and above; dual-channel DDR 400; SATA and IDE RAID; Gigabit Ethernet; USB 2.0; 3 Firewire ports

Price: Rs 13,000
Contact: Cyberstar Infocom Ltd
Phone: 080-227 6986
Fax: 080-223 6781
E-mail: narend@cyberstarin.net
Web site: www.msi.com.tw

MSI 865PE Neo2		B+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	